

However, the state Government is surreptitiously silent on the role of its Water Resources Minister Vijendra Prasad Yadav, whose task was to ensure maintenance of the barrage. He failed terribly on this account. Ironically, Yadav himself is an MLA from Supaul and therefore was well aware of the threat perception. Now many parts of his district may never emerge from water unless the Kosi's flow is changed. It is clear that the administration in the affected districts, besides the Water Resources Department, was caught napping. "They thought that the Kosi waters, like previous years, would go the traditional way after vainly hitting the East afflux embankment near Kusaha. In their smugness, they even overlooked the breach that is now too big to be plugged easily," said an official of disaster management wing. Water re-

Meanwhile, according to Additional Secretary, Disaster Management, Pratyay Amrit, carrying out relief operations in many areas has been a herculean task because, even as the flood water is enough to submerge the localities, the water level is too less to let the relief boats ply. At the same time the administration cannot wait for the level to rise sufficiently because by then the devastation will be total. The situation has become so grim that even the relief camps set up in safe zones are being shifted because of the ever-swelling waters. Over 75 such camps have been set up for some 70,000 people who have been rescued so far. However, the people who were marooned are reluctant to abandon their homes because they think the waters will recede as it happens during the regular floods. But the chief minister has appealed to them to evacu-

NO END TO SQUABBLING:
Lalu Prasad (left) and Nitish Kumar



Lalu Prasad Yadav flew in to Bihar and Nitish Kumar petitioned the Centre, but instead of relief and rescue, they were more interested in scoring brownie points.

source engineers say because of the archaic cement-boulder approach, plans to place boulders to stop the water flow would turn out to be a long-drawn exercise. Yet, according to Superintending Engineer Ashram Rai, more than 11,000 boulders were made available before the breach actually happened. The engineers could not put them to use because of the "law and order situation in Nepal".

So far, Union ministers Lalu Prasad Yadav and Ram Vilas Paswan have undertaken aerial surveys of the affected localities. The subsequent press conferences that the two leaders have convened were full of political overtones. Despite claims to the contrary, the emphasis like always was on scoring brownie points.

ate the areas at the earliest.

The water channel emerging from the breach point has now become the main stream and the volume of water may continue to increase till October. The breach in the embankment can be plugged only after the Kosi flow is regulated back to its traditional course, which is being attempted by digging channels to guide the water back to the main river bed. But this is a time-consuming process and is unlikely to be over before October 31. The breach, therefore, can be mended only by November, which will make the relief operations one of the longest of all times. It is unfortunate that even as people suffer an avoidable tragedy, the political leaders are busy passing the buck. ■